

The haka
The *haka* (literally meaning "dance") was originally performed by warriors before a battle, proclaiming their strength and prowess in order to intimidate the opposition. Today, the *haka* is an integral part of formal welcome ceremonies for distinguished visitors or foreign dignitaries *(above)*. Facial tattoos, a Polynesian custom, indicated a warrior's ancestry, status, and fighting prowess. The carved jade *hei-tiki (right)* is a neck pendant worn by the Maori, who esteem jade highly for its beauty and resilience.

POLYNESIAN FARMERS AND SAILORS, the Maori settled in New Zealand some time between 800 and 1300 CE. Warfare was a central part of their traditional culture. They built fortified villages for defence and organized war parties every year to fight their neighbours. In the 19th century, contact with Europeans added muskets to the Maori's traditional wood-and-stone weaponry. Equipped with firearms, the Maori fought a series of costly wars – the Musket Wars – against one another, and the British army.

Much about the pre-colonial history of the Maori is a matter of dispute, including the causes and nature of their warfare. It would appear that, as in many societies before modern times, war was regarded as a normal activity to be engaged in at the appropriate time of year. Male Maori were trained up to be warriors, or *toa*, from boyhood. Since different Maori tribes lived in close proximity on well populated coastal farmland, motives for fighting with neighbours were never in short supply. Some anthropologists have argued that the Maori battled mainly over possession of scarce land, but less obviously rational motives seem actually to have predominated. The Maori were highly sensitive to any insult or injury, memory of which might be transmitted through generations. Military action was justified in pursuit of vengeance (*utu*) for whatever offence the tribal chief felt that he had suffered. Combat was also an end in itself, providing the *toa* with a chance to prove their valour and their chief with an opportunity to enhance his status.

RITUAL AND MASSACRE

Maori warriors would form a war party on their chief's orders; typically between 70 and 140 men constituted a warband – 70 was the number that would fit in a war canoe, the usual mode of transport for warriors. Various rituals had to be observed before setting off, including the rehearsal of grievances against the enemy and the avoidance of certain foods. Ambushes and surprise attacks played a major part in Maori warfare, but inevitably opposing forces would sometimes confront one another in open combat. In preparation for battle, warriors would perform a dance (the *haka*); this was a combination of war chants and aggressive gestures with grotesque grimaces designed to intimidate the enemy.

The warriors would probably be naked but for a belt around their waist. They fought with wooden spears and clubs, given a sharp edge by incorporating pieces of stone, coral, bone, or shell. Despite ritualized elements that sometimes limited casualties, Maori warfare could be brutal and thoroughly deadly. If an enemy force tried to flee, for example, the fleetest warriors might pursue them, striking as many as possible to the ground with their spears without stopping. The injured men would then be overtaken by slower-moving warriors following on behind who ruthlessly slaughtered them with clubs and axes. Similarly, a warband that fell into an ambush could often expect to be killed to the last man. After a victory, some of the dead enemy would be eaten, for religious rather than nutritional reasons, and their embalmed heads exhibited around the village as trophies of battle.

The principle of vengeance could have led to wars of extermination, since if only some of the enemy were killed, the survivors would inevitably return to seek revenge. What usually prevented the total massacre or enslavement of tribes were their strong defensive preparations. The Maori built *pa (*fortified strongholds) on hill-tops, surrounded by palisades, ditches, and banks, and incorporating food stores that would enable them to survive a lengthy siege. Once withdrawn within these defences, the Maori were unlikely to be overrun, even by a clearly stronger enemy.



JADE HEI-TIKI (NECK PENDANT)